

The Aon (cut-e) Assessment

A Complete Mastery Guide

From zero knowledge to test-ready: what the assessment is, exactly how it is marked, the anti-cheating machinery, the full mechanics of the numerical and verbal reasoning tests, every trap, the ordered thought process for each question type, and the daily and weekly training routines that build mastery.

Compiled 30 August 2026 · from primary-source research (Aon official practice materials + established assessment vendors) · for legitimate preparation only

Companion to the Aon scales trainer app (unlimited verified practice questions, progress tracking, adaptive drilling).

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PART I — Understand The Game

What the Aon (cut-e) assessment actually is, which firms use it, exactly how it is marked, and the anti-cheating machinery — the information asymmetry, closed.

1. What you are facing, from zero

1.1 The vendor and the product

Aon Assessment Solutions is the assessments arm of Aon plc, built around **cut-e**, a Hamburg psychometrics firm Aon acquired in 2017. Employers still call the tests "cut-e" and the product family is branded "**scales**": scales numerical, scales verbal, scales ix, scales lst, scales cls, and more, plus a gamified mobile battery called **smartPredict**. When a firm like Schrodgers sends you an "online assessment" powered by Aon, you are almost always facing one or more of these modules.

Aon tests feel different from the other big vendors (SHL, Korn Ferry/Talent Q, Kenexa) in four ways, and each one changes how you should prepare:

1. **Short and dense.** Modules run 5–12 minutes with many small items (~15–20 seconds each), rather than 25 minutes of long multi-part questions.
2. **Machine-generated item banks.** Every candidate draws a different randomised set from a large bank. There is no leaked paper to memorise — by design.
3. **Negative marking.** Wrong answers subtract from your score; blanks do not. This inverts the "always guess" advice you may know from other tests (full maths in chapter 2).
4. **The Cannot Say button.** The numerical and verbal tests are three-option judgement tests where knowing that the data is insufficient is itself the tested skill.

1.2 The tests you will actually meet

Your focus — the maths, verbal-reasoning and written components — maps to two core modules, with a supporting cast you should at least recognise:

- **scales numerical** ("the maths one"): ~6 tabs of charts and tables about one company; judge statements True / False / Cannot Say. 37 items / 12 min (or 18 / 6 min short form). Chapter 4.
- **scales verbal** ("the written one"): ~5–6 tabs of short passages about one company; the same three-way judgement. Up to ~49 items / 12 min. Chapter 5.
- **The logical/abstract family** (ix, lst, cls, sx) and **gridChallenge / smartPredict**: shape- and memory-based modules some employers add. Chapter 6 gives you the full map.

Some employers also attach a situational-judgement questionnaire or behavioural/personality section to the same sitting. Those are not covered by this guide's drills (they are not marked right/wrong in the same way), but knowing they may follow the cognitive modules helps you budget energy on the day.

1.3 Where the test sits in the funnel

Typically: application → online assessment (this) → video interview or further tests → assessment centre / final interviews. The online test is a **volume filter**: it exists to cut a large applicant pool down cheaply, which is why the bar is percentile-based and why so many otherwise strong candidates are eliminated by it. Passing does not usually feed a later ranking directly — clearing the bar is what matters — but a re-test of the same module can appear at the assessment-centre stage (chapter 3).

1.4 Which firms use it — and a critical correction about Schrodgers

Research date: 30 August 2026. Vendors change, so re-verify close to any application — but the picture below is built from first-party careers pages where possible, with confidence noted.

The Schroders correction. Schroders IS an Aon client — its own careers FAQ names "Aon (our online assessments provider)". But its current online battery is **not** the classic numerical/verbal tests. Schroders' stage-2 assessment (confirmed first-party) is: **chatAssess** (a gamified situational-judgement test, ~15–20 questions), **switchChallenge** (deductive logic — identify the operator that transforms symbol rows, 6 minutes, adaptive), and **ADEPT-15** (a ~100-statement personality questionnaire, untimed). Several prep sites still describe an SHL numerical/verbal battery for Schroders — that is their *old* provider and those pages are stale. If Schroders is your target: prioritise fast deductive-logic work (switchChallenge is in the same family as the Ist/ix drills in this guide's trainer), take chatAssess/ADEPT-15 honestly and consistently (they are values-fit instruments, not right/wrong tests), and treat the numerical/verbal mastery in this guide as your weapon for the other firms below.

Confirmed Aon (cut-e) users where the classic scales tests apply

Employer	What candidates report facing	Confidence
UBS	Aon numerical (the 37-in-12 True/False/Cannot Say described in ch.4), verbal, inductive, plus a "Cultural Match" appraisal. Stage 2, before video interview. (Switched from SHL.)	High
Morgan Stanley	Aon numerical, verbal and logical reasoning plus an Aon situational-judgement questionnaire.	High
Nomura	Aon/cut-e aptitude tests (numerical/verbal/logical).	High
BNP Paribas	Aon numerical and verbal reasoning.	High
Schroders	Aon — but chatAssess + switchChallenge + ADEPT-15 (see box above), ~40 min total, then a video interview also on the Aon platform (~2 min prep + 2 min record per question).	High (first-party)
Credit Suisse (legacy)	Was a cut-e user; absorbed into UBS in 2023 — apply via UBS.	High (historic)
AXA · Crédit Agricole · ANZ	Listed as cut-e finance clients by an established vendor.	Medium
easyJet · Lufthansa · British Airways cadets	The Aon scales battery for pilot/cadet screening.	High
Rolls-Royce · Vodafone · O2 · Siemens · Allianz · P&G · Airbus and other large European employers	Various scales modules; Aon is strongest in UK and German-speaking markets.	Medium

Firms where this prep does NOT transfer (different vendors)

Deloitte UK (Cappfinity immersive assessment) · Deutsche Bank, Barclays, Jefferies (SHL) · HSBC (Cappfinity) · Macquarie (Korn Ferry/Talent Q) · Blackstone, Standard Chartered (Pymetrics). No evidence was found that the big UK insurers (Aviva, Zurich, L&G, Admiral, Hiscox) use Aon for graduate screening. Always check the assessment invitation email — it names the platform.

Stage placement and thresholds at these firms

- The pattern at confirmed users: application → Aon tests sent almost immediately (the first real filter, usually before any human reads your CV) → video interview (often on Aon's own platform) → assessment centre. At Schroders the video interviews are reportedly reviewed in batches close to assessment-centre dates,

which explains multi-week silences candidates describe.

- No employer publishes its cut-off. Vendor folklore for competitive finance schemes clusters around the **70th–80th percentile** (Stanine 6–7); investment-facing roles are said to sit higher. Treat as directional (Medium confidence at best).
- Behavioural components (chatAssess, ADEPT-15, Cultural Match) are scored against the firm's values profile, not as right/wrong — consistency and honest self-description matter, because personality instruments include internal-consistency checks.
- Schroders reapplication lockout: one application per programme per 12 months — another reason to walk in prepared the first time.

2. How you are marked — closing the information asymmetry

This is the chapter most candidates never read, and it changes every tactical decision in the test. Aon does not publish its full scoring internals, so below each claim carries the confidence the evidence supports. Where sources conflict, both sides are stated.

2.1 The scoring model

Fact	Detail	Confidence
Negative marking	Correct +1 · incorrect –1 · unanswered 0. Aon's own candidate guidance: incorrect answers "have a negative effect on the final results". Multiple vendors state the flat one-mark deduction.	High
Blanks are safe	An unanswered item scores zero — it is never penalised. Vendors uniformly advise leaving blanks over guessing.	High
Penalty size	Flat –1 is the well-supported figure. Fractional penalties (–1/3, –1/4) appear only in low-quality sources and are probably confusion with other vendors' formula scoring.	Medium
Speed weighting	No per-item speed bonus on numerical/verbal. Speed matters only because faster accurate work attempts more items. (Reaction-time weighting exists in some Aon personality/gamified products, not these.)	Medium-High
Not adaptive	scales numerical/verbal are fixed-length draws from a randomised bank, not question-by-question adaptive tests — free back-navigation proves it. (smartPredict IS adaptive.)	Medium-High
Wrong-tab quirk	Several established vendors report that submitting while the wrong data tab is displayed reduces points even when the answer is right. Not confirmed in Aon's own documents; cheap to guard against, so guard against it.	Medium

2.2 The guessing mathematics — memorise this

With three options and negative marking, a blind guess has expected value $1/3 \times (+1) + 2/3 \times (-1) = -1/3$ of a point. A blank is exactly 0. So every blind guess is, on average, a third of a point donated back to the test. Eliminate one option and a coin-flip guess becomes EV 0 — break-even, worth taking only if you lean one way. The rule that falls out:

Answer when you can justify it. Guess only when you can eliminate at least one option. Otherwise leave it blank — the blank is a scoring move, not a failure.

2.3 Norm referencing — what your score becomes

Your raw score is not compared to a pass mark; it is compared to a **norm group** (typically a country + role-level pool, e.g. UK graduate applicants) and reported as a **percentile** and/or a **Stanine** — a 1–9 scale where 5 is average:

Stanine	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
Percentile band	≤4	5–11	12–23	24–40	41–60	61–77	78–89	90–96	97+

Each employer sets its own cut-off and does not publish it. Prep-industry folklore puts competitive graduate schemes around the 60th–80th percentile (Stanine 6–7); treat that as directional, not gospel. Three practical consequences:

- The test feeling savagely hard tells you nothing — it is hard for the whole norm group, and the bar is relative.
- You do not need a perfect score; you need to beat enough of the pool. Consistent 75–85% accuracy on attempted items with disciplined blanks is a genuinely strong profile.
- Small skill gains move you a long way: percentiles are densest in the middle of the pool, so going from "average" to "somewhat better than average" can jump you 15–20 percentile points.

2.4 You are not meant to finish

The tests are deliberately over-length (37 numerical items in 12 minutes; up to ~49 verbal items). Aon's own practice material says you are not expected to answer everything — "work quickly and accurately". Combined with negative marking, the strategy is unambiguous: **accuracy dominates coverage**. The failure mode that kills most candidates is racing to see every item and littering the attempt with –1s.

3. The anti-cheating machinery — and why it sets your strategy

You asked how they stop cheating. The honest answer: thoroughly, and in a way that makes skill-building the only rational preparation. Three layers:

- 1. Unique tests per candidate.** Items are generated/drawn from large banks at sitting time. Your test is not your friend's test. Memorised answers have nothing to attach to.
- 2. Proctoring options.** Employers can enable webcam/audio monitoring and browser lockdown for the unsupervised stage. Assume the tab-switching and copy-paste behaviour of your sitting can be observed.
- 3. The supervised re-test.** The decisive layer. Aon's guidance, repeated verbatim by major vendors: *"If you are invited to an interview after the online assessment, you will be expected to complete a repeat module from the online assessment. If you cheated in the online assessment, it will come to light during the retest, at the very latest."* Candidates whose supervised score collapses against their unsupervised one are excluded.

Follow the logic to its end: an inflated first-round score does not get you a job — it gets you a supervised re-sit you cannot pass, later in the process, after you have invested weeks. The only score that survives the whole funnel is one produced by actual ability. That is not a moral lecture; it is the mechanism design. It is also good news: **the skill is very trainable**, the format is stable and knowable, and everything in Parts II and III transfers fully to the real, proctored, re-tested assessment.

PART II — The Tests In Depth

Exactly what each test looks like, the decision rules that mark it, the traps built into it, and the ordered thought process to run on every single question.

4. scales numerical — the maths test, from zero

This is the test most people mean when they say "the Aon maths test". You are shown roughly **six data displays about one fictional company** — tables and charts arranged as clickable tabs across the top of the screen. Below them, one statement at a time appears, and you must judge it:

TRUE — the data confirms the statement, exactly. **FALSE** — the data contradicts it, even slightly.

CANNOT SAY — a figure the statement needs is not shown anywhere, so it can be neither confirmed nor denied.

That third button is what makes this test different from school maths. It is not only testing whether you can calculate — it is testing whether you know **when you cannot**. Aon's own practice material states the principle plainly: each statement relates to the given data sheets, you need no outside knowledge, and you must find and refer to the relevant data sheet yourself.

Format and timing

Property	Value
Long form	37 tasks in 12:00 (about 19–20 seconds per item)
Short form	18 tasks in 6:00 (about 20 seconds per item)
Displays	~6 tabbed data sheets, fixed for the whole test; one statement per screen
Answers	True / False / Cannot Say — exactly one is correct
Tools	On-screen calculator provided; pen and paper allowed
Navigation	You can move between questions and change answers (a back toggle exists in some deployments)
Warm-up	~4–5 extra minutes of instructions and unscored practice items before the clock starts

Twenty seconds per item sounds brutal, and it is meant to. But remember from Part I: you are **not expected to finish**, and a wrong answer costs a point while a blank costs nothing. The test rewards a calm, accurate 25 answers far more than a panicked 37.

4.1 The six displays — what the charts actually look like

Aon's official practice pack uses a small, consistent set of visual forms, and knowing them in advance saves seconds on every question. In rough order of frequency:

- **Plain data table** — dark header row, rows of figures by category and year, often a bold **Total** row, and a units footnote underneath such as "*All data in thousand dollars*". The most common display, and home of the units trap.
- **Doughnut / pie chart** — percentage shares with the % printed by each slice, a legend below, and crucially an **absolute total captioned underneath** (e.g. "Total product revenue was \$86 million"). Questions often need slice % × that total.
- **Stacked column chart** — e.g. employees by region stacked per year, values printed inside each segment, the unit hidden in the axis title ("Number of employees *in thousands*").

- **Grouped horizontal bar** — Aon's forecast form: years down the side, bars grouped by product, values printed at the bar ends, unit in the axis title ("Pieces produced *in million*").
- **Line chart** — a metric over time, one line per category; check whether the axis starts at zero or is an index.

Two habits follow directly. First, in your opening seconds, learn what each tab holds. Second, on every display, **read the unit before you read any number** — the unit lives in a footnote or an axis title, and it is deliberately part of the test.

4.2 The decision rule, precisely

These definitions come from Aon's own worked examples, so treat them as the marking scheme:

1. **TRUE** requires exact confirmation. If the table (in \$ thousand) shows 7,256 and the statement says "research costs exceeded \$7 million", convert: 7,256 thousand = \$7.256m > \$7m → True.
2. **FALSE** is triggered by any contradiction — including a near miss. Aon's example: the data implies an increase of 1,550,000; the statement claims 1,500,000. Their rationale: "*the figures are close, but the statement was not asking for an approximation*" → False.
3. **CANNOT SAY** means a required figure is absent: a year outside the range shown, a category not listed, or — the subtlest form — the wrong **type** of quantity (the statement asks about units sold; the tab only shows revenue). You cannot decide, so you must not.

The operational test to run in your head: "Can I prove this 100% true or 100% false from what is on the tabs?" If one required number is missing → Cannot Say. If everything is present but disagrees → False. Committing to True/False on evidence that only *suggests* is the single biggest score-killer in this test.

4.3 The 7-step drill — run this on every question

This is the ordered thought process. Drill it until it is automatic; under time pressure you fall to the level of your habits, not your intentions.

0. **Orient (once, ~20 seconds at the start).** Click each tab once. Note three things only: its name, its form (table / doughnut / bars / line), and its unit. Do not read numbers yet. You are building a map so that later, "margin" instantly means "third tab, line chart, %."
1. **Read the statement twice, literally.** Extract five things: the entity (which region/segment), the period (which year), the quantity type (revenue? units? margin?), the number and comparator ("more than \$7m", "exactly", "rose 10%"), and any trap word (% , percentage points, all/every, exactly, approximately).
2. **The Cannot-Say gate.** Before any maths: is this exact quantity, for this entity, in this period, shown on any tab? Quantity type not displayed → Cannot Say, stop. Year outside the range → Cannot Say, stop. Entity not listed → Cannot Say, stop. This one check decides roughly a quarter of items at zero calculation cost.
3. **Open the one tab; read the unit first, then the figure.** Footnote or axis title before any number. If the statement's unit differs, convert immediately (thousand ↔ million).
4. **Do the minimal operation the wording demands.** "Exceeded X" → read and compare, no maths. "Rose by X%" → $(\text{new} - \text{old}) \div \text{old} \times 100$. "Rose X percentage points" → subtract the two rates. "X% of total" → $\text{part} \div \text{total} \times 100$. "Profit / per head" → combine two tabs. "Highest" → scan all entities. "Every year" → check each step; one exception kills it. Where possible, compare before you compute — many items only need "is A bigger than B?".
5. **Apply the decision rule** from 4.2: exact confirmation → True; any contradiction → False; missing figure → Cannot Say.
6. **Two-second sanity gate.** (a) Is the correct tab still displayed? (Several sources report that answering with the wrong tab open costs points even when you are right.) (b) Did I answer the quantity actually asked, not a look-alike? (c) Am I about to say True on something the data only suggests? Then click.

7. Time gate. Not cracked by ~30 seconds? Blank it (0, no penalty) and move on. Return only if time remains at the end.

4.4 Reading financial statements — for Schroders-style finance variants

Aon sells sector-flavoured versions of the numerical test, and finance employers typically get the finance flavour: the tabs read like extracts from a company's accounts. If you are applying to asset managers, banks or insurers, learn these three structures cold — not to accounting-exam depth, but enough that the vocabulary costs you zero seconds.

The income statement (P&L) — a flow over a period

Revenue – Cost of Sales = **Gross Profit**. Gross Profit – Operating Expenses = **Operating Profit**. After interest and tax: **Net Profit**. The margins divide each profit line by revenue: gross margin = gross profit ÷ revenue, and so on. EPS = net profit ÷ shares.

Question shapes: "Segment X's gross profit exceeded \$Ym" → revenue tab minus cost-of-sales tab (two tabs, possibly different units). "Gross margin was above 40%" → a ratio, or a direct read if a margin tab exists. Watch the difference between a margin (a %) and a change in margin (percentage points).

The balance sheet — a snapshot at a date

The identity: Assets = Liabilities + Equity, so **Net Assets (Equity) = Assets – Liabilities**. Return on Assets = profit ÷ assets. Gearing = debt ÷ equity. Current ratio = current assets ÷ current liabilities.

Question shapes: "Net assets for the division exceeded £Xm" → assets tab minus liabilities tab. "Return on assets rose more than 2 percentage points" → subtract the two ROA rates; do not compute a % change.

The cash flow statement — cash in and out over a period

Operating Cash Flow – Capital Expenditure = **Free Cash Flow**. Cash conversion = operating cash flow ÷ operating profit. The classic trap: **cash flow is not profit** — a profit figure cannot answer a cash-flow question (that is a data-type mismatch → Cannot Say).

Reading order for any statement-style table: units footnote → the **exact line label** (Gross Profit is not Net Profit; Assets is not Net Assets) → the period column → beware the Total row.

4.5 Every trap, with the fix

Trap	How it catches you	The fix
Units (thousands vs millions)	Table says "in \$ thousand"; 7,256 is read as \$7,256 instead of \$7.256m	Read the footnote/axis unit before any number; convert to the statement's unit
Close-but-not-exact	Data implies 1,550,000; statement says 1,500,000 — "close enough" feels True	Unless it says "approximately", any mismatch is False
Missing period / entity	Statement names FY3; tabs show FY5–FY8. You estimate from the trend	Never extrapolate. Not shown → Cannot Say
% vs percentage points	Margin 10% → 15% called "up 5%" (it is +5 points, +50% relative)	"Points" → subtract rates. "%" → divide change by the original
Data-type mismatch	Asks units sold; tab shows revenue (or revenue share). Numbers are visible, so you compute	Match the quantity type exactly; wrong type → Cannot Say
Two-display combination	Slice % looks like an amount; profit needs two tabs	List every figure needed and its tab before combining; units may differ
Total-row distractor	The bold Total sits next to the line item you need	Read the exact row label, every time
Index / base-100	Index 130 read as "130 units"	Index points are relative: 100 → 130 is +30%; absolute claims about an index → usually Cannot Say
Compound %	+12% then –8% called +4%	Chain multiplicatively: $\times 1.12 \times 0.92 = -0.96\%$

Trap	How it catches you	The fix
Biggest absolute $\neq$ biggest %	Largest raw change picked as "largest growth"	Divide each change by its own base before ranking
Axis not at zero	Bar heights exaggerate differences	Read the numbers, not the ink

4.6 What each difficulty level looks like

The reasoning, not just the arithmetic, is what scales. Know which level you are training at:

- **Beginner-level items:** one tab, one figure, a single consistent unit, a clearly present or clearly absent data point. The skill being built: the 7-step habit, the decision rule, and reading each chart form quickly.
- **Intermediate items:** a unit conversion (thousands vs millions), a percentage change computed against the right base, a share of a captioned total, a Cannot Say hidden as a missing year. The skill: doing one transformation under time pressure without dropping accuracy.
- **Advanced items:** two tabs combined (profit, per-head ratios) with different units, percentage-points phrasing, index/base-100 displays, data-type-mismatch Cannot Says, rank-by-growth questions. The skill: holding a two-step plan in your head and still running the sanity gate before clicking.

4.7 A complete worked example

Tabs: Revenue (table, \$ thousand) · Cost of Sales (table, \$ thousand) · Revenue Mix (doughnut) · Headcount · Gross Margin (line, %) · EPS Index. Statement: **"Online's gross profit in FY8 exceeded \$2 million."**

1. Extract: entity = Online; period = FY8; quantity = gross profit (= revenue – cost of sales); comparator = "> \$2m".
2. Cannot-Say gate: both revenue and cost of sales are shown for Online in FY8 → answerable.
3. Revenue tab, unit "\$ thousand": Online FY8 = 5,400 → \$5.4m. Cost of Sales tab: 3,100 → \$3.1m.
4. Gross profit = 5.4 – 3.1 = \$2.3m.
5. 2.3 > 2.0 → **True**.
6. Sanity gate: right tabs, right quantity ("gross profit", not revenue), no over-inference. Click.

5. scales verbal — the written reasoning test, from zero

The verbal test looks like the numerical one — the same tabbed layout, the same three buttons — but the tabs hold **short written passages** instead of charts, all describing one fictional company (its structure, strategy, values, locations, products, people). You judge each statement **True / False / Cannot Say** against the one tab it relates to, and finding that tab is your job. It is a reading-precision test, not a vocabulary or comprehension-speed test.

Format and timing

Property	Value
Length	Up to ~49 statements in 12:00 — roughly 14–15 seconds each (a minority source says 47)
Displays	~5–6 topic tabs, each holding 2–3 short paragraphs about the same company
Answers	True / False / Cannot Say
Navigation	Movement between statements is possible; Aon recommends working in order
Completion	Not expected — Aon's own wording: "work quickly and accurately"

5.1 The decision rule — confirmed against Aon's own worked examples

- 1. True = the tab entails the statement, including through a genuine synonym.** Aon marks "different products made of leather... sourced outside of Italy" as True against a passage saying the firm sold "leather goods" that were "imported" — because the meanings genuinely match.
- 2. False = any contradicted element, even one.** Aon's example: a statement that was right in every respect except calling the courses "online" when the passage said "on-premises" is marked False. One wrong detail sinks the whole statement.
- 3. Cannot Say = the tab neither confirms nor denies it.** Either the attribute is simply never stated, or the statement requires an inference the text does not make (Aon's own trap example attributes website traffic growth to a demographic that the passage only connects to social media — tempting, unstated, Cannot Say).

5.2 The 5-step verbal drill

- 0. Orient.** Skim the tab labels once. Within ~10 questions you will know which tab holds what — that map is most of your speed.
- 1. Extract the claim.** Subject, attribute, and any scope word (all / always / only / never / some / may). Absolutes deserve suspicion on sight.
- 2. Find the one relevant tab and open it.** Answering against the wrong passage can cost the point even when your logic is right.
- 3. Hunt for the specific sentence.** If no sentence addresses the attribute at all → Cannot Say, stop. Do not reason from what is "probably true of companies like this" — that is the outside-knowledge trap, and Aon builds questions specifically to spring it.
- 4. Compare word for word.** Every key word supported (genuine synonyms count) → True. Any detail swapped or contradicted → False. The passage supports only a weaker claim than the statement makes ("several markets" vs "all markets") → Cannot Say.

The two verbal killers: (1) importing outside knowledge — if it is not in the passage, it does not exist; (2) letting an absolute word ("all", "every", "only") ride through on a passage that only supports a general claim. Catch both in step 4 before you click.

5.3 Worked example

Passage (Strategy tab): *"The company plans to expand into several Asian markets over the next three years."*

Statement: **"The company will open stores in every Asian country."**

Step 1: subject = company; attribute = expansion; scope word = **every**. Step 3: the Strategy tab addresses expansion → decidable territory. Step 4: the text supports *several markets*, not *every country*, and says nothing about *stores*. Nothing confirms or denies the stronger claim → **Cannot Say**. (Choosing False is the common error — but the passage does not *contradict* the statement; it just fails to support it.)

5.4 Difficulty progression

- **Beginner**: literal restatements, obvious contradictions, plainly absent attributes.
- **Intermediate**: synonym-True vs paraphrase-flip-False; Cannot Says built from unstated attributes; sector vocabulary (finance flavours read like fund/company descriptions).
- **Advanced**: absolute-quantifier overreach, near-synonyms that do not quite match, plausible outside-knowledge lures, and statements needing two facts joined where the passage supplies one.

6. The rest of the family — so nothing surprises you

Employers frequently bundle two or more Aon tests in one sitting. Each takes minutes to understand; know them all so the invitation email never contains a surprise.

Test	What it is	Time
scales ix ("discovering rules")	Nine abstract objects; eight share a hidden rule (shape, side-count, fill, rotation, inner shape); click the ONE that breaks it. ~20 items.	5 min
scales lst / gapChallenge	Shape sudoku: a grid where each shape appears once per row and column; pick the shape for the "?" cell. 4×4 growing to 5×5; adaptive; you can pre-fill cells to reason.	~6 min
scales cls	Ten 3×3 letter/number grids; six are colour-sorted into two groups by a hidden rule; assign the remaining four. 12 tasks.	12 min
scales clx	Two reference shape-grids share a rule; pick the 2 of 4 candidates that follow it.	~6 min
scales sx / switchChallenge	Identify the operator that reordered a row of symbols; adaptive.	5–6 min
gridChallenge	Working-memory rounds: memorise dot positions while doing interleaved symmetry tasks, then recall in order.	~9 min
scales eq1 / digitChallenge	Mental arithmetic: complete equations using digits 1–9. No calculator.	~5 min
smartPredict	The gamified mobile battery bundling switch/grid/digit/motion challenges; genuinely adaptive.	5–9 min each

The trainer app includes playable versions of ix, lst and cls with the same verified-answer discipline as the numerical and verbal modules, each with its own step-by-step process in the in-app guide.

PART III — Training To Mastery

What "good" actually is, the daily and weekly routines that build it, the mindset and test-day protocol, and how to measure whether you are genuinely improving.

7. The skill model — what you are actually building

Strip away the branding and these tests measure one composite skill: **making accurate, evidence-bounded decisions in under 20 seconds, repeatedly, without degrading**. That decomposes into five trainable sub-skills:

- 1. Format fluency.** Recognising each display type instantly and knowing where its unit, total and labels live. This is cheap to acquire and worth several seconds per item.
- 2. The decision rule as reflex.** True = proven; False = contradicted; Cannot Say = missing. Most failed attempts are not arithmetic failures — they are people answering True to things that were merely plausible.
- 3. Fast, reliable core arithmetic.** Percentage change, percentage points, shares, ratios, unit conversion — done in one pass, with estimation used to avoid computation where possible.
- 4. Skip discipline.** Feeling the 30-second mark, blanking without regret, and re-entering the next question clean. Under negative marking this is a scoring skill, not a coping strategy.
- 5. Error self-knowledge.** Knowing which of the named error categories (below, §10) is *your* leak, and drilling that one specifically. Untargeted volume practice plateaus; targeted practice does not.

Everything in the routines below exists to train one of those five. When a session feels aimless, ask which sub-skill it was for.

8. Daily and weekly routines

8.1 The daily session template (30–40 minutes)

Block	Minutes	What you do
Warm-up	5	Ten mental-arithmetic reps: percentage changes, thousand→million conversions, quick share calculations. No calculator. Purpose: arithmetic is warm before judgement is tested.
Focused drill	15	One module, untimed or lightly timed, aimed at YOUR current weakest category (the trainer's adaptive mode serves this automatically). Run the full step drill on every item, out loud at first.
Timed block	10	One short timed set at real pace (~15–20s/item). Practise the skip rule live. Expect accuracy to dip vs the drill — the gap between the two IS your time-pressure cost, and shrinking it is the goal.
Review	10	The non-negotiable block. Read the worked solution for every miss AND every slow-correct. Name the error category out loud. Reviewing is where improvement happens; answering is just where evidence is generated.

If you only have 15 minutes: do the focused drill and the review. Never do a timed block without reviewing it — unreviewed mocks teach you nothing except anxiety.

8.2 The weekly shape

- **4–5 skill days** (the template above), rotating modules but overweighting numerical and verbal in your case.
- **1 simulation day:** full-length mocks back to back under exact conditions — timer visible, calculator and paper as allowed, no pausing. Then a full review pass.

- **1 light or rest day:** read the guide sections for your weak categories, or nothing. Consolidation is real; fried practice is negative practice.
- **Weekly audit (10 minutes):** open the progress screen. Write down: accuracy by module, your two weakest categories, average seconds per item, and blanks-vs-wrong ratio. Next week's focused drills target exactly those two categories.

8.3 The two-week intensive (before a live test)

Days	Focus
1–2	Numerical + verbal untimed. Internalise the decision rule; read every worked solution, including for correct answers. Target: zero "missed Cannot Say" by day 2.
3–4	Trap immersion: units, % vs points, data-type mismatch (numerical); outside-knowledge and absolutes (verbal). Adaptive drills on whatever the tracker flags.
5–6	Introduce the clock: short timed sets at real pace. Practise skipping. One logical-family session so ix/lst/cls are familiar.
7	Audit + rest. Identify the two weakest categories for week two.
8–9	Full-length numerical and verbal mocks, one per day, full review after each. Watch the naive-vs-net score gap shrink — that gap is careless wrong answers.
10–11	Adaptive drills at advanced tier on the audit's weak spots. One mixed session (numerical + verbal back to back) for context-switching stamina.
12–13	Dress rehearsals under exact test conditions at your target tier. Evening: light review only.
14	Rest, or one gentle untimed set. Prepare the test-day environment (§9). Sleep properly.

8.4 The four-week mastery track (if you have longer)

Weeks 1–2 as above but gentler (skill days only, no full mocks until day 10). Week 3: raise the tier to advanced and add the finance-statement flavours until the vocabulary costs zero seconds. Week 4: simulation-heavy — three full mock days, each followed by a targeted drill day built from that mock's error audit. By the end, your tracked accuracy at real pace should be stable or rising across three consecutive mocks; that stability, not any single score, is the readiness signal.

9. Mindset and the test-day protocol

9.1 The mindset that fits the scoring model

- **You are not trying to finish.** The test is over-length by design. The candidates who fail are usually the ones who tried to see all 37 items; the ones who pass answered fewer, correctly.
- **A blank is a decision, not a failure.** Under negative marking, a disciplined blank outscores a hopeful guess by two-thirds of a point on average. Reframe skipping as scoring.
- **One question at a time.** The previous item is gone; it cannot be helped or harmed. Rumination during item n is the main cause of an error on item $n+1$.
- **Percentile thinking.** Everyone finds it hard — it is normed. The test feeling brutal is not information about how you are doing relative to the pool.
- **Trust the drill under stress.** The 7-step and 5-step processes exist precisely for the moment your head goes blank. When panicking: exhale slowly once, put your eyes on the statement, and start step 1. The procedure restarts the thinking.

9.2 Before the test

- Do the official practice items Aon offers in the invitation — they are unscored and confirm the exact modules you will face.

- Environment: quiet room, laptop on power, wired internet if possible, phone away, water, pen and plenty of paper. Close every other tab and every notification source.
- Warm up for 10–15 minutes with one light trainer set an hour before — warm arithmetic, calm pace. Do not do a full mock on test day.
- Know the mechanics in advance: whole-test countdown, on-screen calculator (numerical), back-navigation possible but working in order recommended, unscored instruction time before the clock.

9.3 During the test

1. Use the instruction/practice minutes fully — they are free and untimed.
2. Spend your first ~20 seconds on the tab map (numerical) or label skim (verbal).
3. Run the drill on every item. Watch the trap words. Confirm the tab before every submit.
4. Hold the skip rule mechanically: ~30 seconds numerical, ~25 verbal, then blank and move.
5. If time remains at the end, revisit blanks — but never convert a blank to a guess you cannot at least partially justify.

10. Measuring progress — the error taxonomy

Track errors by **cause**, not by count. These are the categories the trainer logs automatically; if practising elsewhere, log them by hand:

Category	What it means	The targeted fix
Missed Cannot Say	Answered True/False when a required figure or fact was absent	Drill step 2 (the gate) in isolation; untimed Cannot-Say-heavy sets
Over-cautious	Answered Cannot Say when the data was sufficient	Slow down step 3: the figure was there — practise locating before judging
Unit / scale error	Thousands vs millions, % vs absolute	Read-the-unit-first habit; conversion warm-ups
% vs percentage points	Divided when you should subtract, or vice versa	Formula card (Appendix B); 10 dedicated reps
Wrong tab	Answered against the wrong display/passage	Re-run step 0 orientation; confirm-tab habit in the sanity gate
Arithmetic slip	Right plan, wrong sum	Use the calculator for multi-step; estimate first to sanity-bound the result
Outside knowledge (verbal)	Judged on plausibility, not the passage	Quote-the-sentence discipline: no sentence, no True/False
Quantifier overreach (verbal)	Let "all/every/only" ride through	Circle scope words in step 1
Panic guess	Fast wrong answer under pressure	Skip-rule drilling; breathing reset; accept the blank
Slow-but-correct	Right, but over budget — it silently costs coverage	Identify which step is slow (usually locating, not computing) and drill that step

The readiness signals to watch across weeks: accuracy-on-attempted rising toward and past ~80% at real pace; missed-Cannot-Say and wrong-tab trending to zero; the naive-vs-net score gap closing; and stability across consecutive mocks. Coverage rises on its own as the drill gets faster — never chase it directly.

11. Your toolkit

- **The trainer app** (built alongside this guide): unlimited generated questions for numerical, verbal, ix, lst and cls with provably-correct answers, real-matching chart types, finance-statement flavours, negative-marking

scoring, per-question worked solutions, error diagnosis, a progress dashboard and adaptive drilling. Run locally with `npm run dev`, or use the shared link.

- **Aon's official practice:** the practice-task PDFs for numerical and verbal reasoning on aon.com (the worked examples in this guide are drawn from them), plus the unscored practice items inside any real test invitation. Always do these — they are the ground truth for format.
- **Vendor practice** (JobTestPrep, AssessmentDay, Practice Aptitude Tests, GraduatesFirst, Fintest): useful for additional cut-e-style mocks and their free sample sets. Treat their scoring claims as secondary to the primary sources cited here.
- **Pen, paper, and a simple calculator** — practise with exactly the tools the real test allows, from day one.

Appendix A — One-page drill cards

A.1 Numerical (True / False / Cannot Say over data)

ORIENT tabs (name · form · unit) → READ statement twice (entity · period · quantity · number · trap word) → GATE: is it even shown? no → Cannot Say → OPEN tab, UNIT first → MINIMAL maths → RULE: proven/contradicted/missing → SANITY: right tab? right quantity? not over-inferring? → CLICK. 30 seconds gone? BLANK and move.

A.2 Verbal (True / False / Cannot Say over text)

SKIM tab labels → EXTRACT claim (subject · attribute · scope word) → FIND the one tab → HUNT the sentence; none → Cannot Say → COMPARE word-for-word: synonyms count as True, one swapped detail is False, weaker-than-claimed is Cannot Say → no outside knowledge, no absolutes on general text → CLICK. 25 seconds gone? BLANK and move.

A.3 The scoring facts to remember mid-test

- Correct +1 · wrong −1 · blank 0. Random guess EV = $-1/3$. After eliminating one option EV = 0.
- Nobody finishes. Accuracy beats coverage. The blank is a scoring move.
- Percentile-marked: hard for everyone is the design, not feedback about you.

Appendix B — Formula and conversion card

Need	Formula / rule
Percentage change	$(\text{new} - \text{old}) \div \text{old} \times 100$ — divide by the ORIGINAL
Percentage points	new rate − old rate (subtract; never divide)
Share of total	$\text{part} \div \text{total} \times 100$
Amount from a share	share % × captioned total
Reverse %	if B is 25% more than A, then $A = B \div 1.25$ (not $B \times 0.75$)
Compound change	chain multipliers: +12% then −8% = $1.12 \times 0.92 = 1.0304...$ ($\approx +3.0\%$)... never add
Thousand ↔ million	7,256 thousand = 7.256 million; 0.4 million = 400 thousand
Index (base 100)	index 130 = +30% vs base; index points are NOT absolute quantities
Growth ranking	divide each change by its own base before comparing
Gross profit	revenue − cost of sales; margin = profit ÷ revenue
Net assets	assets − liabilities
Free cash flow	operating cash flow − capital expenditure

Appendix C — Sources and confidence notes

This guide was compiled from multiple independent research passes (July–August 2026). Primary sources were preferred wherever they exist; every load-bearing claim in the text carries the confidence its evidence supports. Where sources conflicted (verbal item count 47 vs 49; the exact penalty magnitude; the wrong-tab penalty; back-navigation freedom), the conflict is stated in place rather than resolved by fiat.

Primary (highest authority)

- Aon official practice tasks — numerical reasoning PDF (aon.com/getmedia/3cc4d7fa...): five worked examples with Aon's own rationale; source of the decision rule, the units and exactness traps, and the chart forms replicated in the trainer.
- Aon official practice tasks — verbal reasoning PDF (aon.com/getmedia/a9d04647...): five worked examples; source of the synonym-True / partial-contradiction-False / unstated-inference-Cannot-Say rulings.
- Aon candidate preparation page (aon.com — "prepare for your online assessment"): scoring direction ("incorrect answers generally have a negative effect"), practice guidance, and the supervised re-test warning quoted in chapter 3.
- Schrodgers careers FAQ (schrodgers.com): first-party confirmation of Aon as provider and of the chatAssess + switchChallenge + ADEPT-15 battery.

Established vendors (corroborating; used where consistent with each other)

- JobTestPrep (UK & US) · AssessmentDay · Practice Aptitude Tests · GraduatesFirst · Fintest · psychometric-success · psychometrictests.org · 123test · MConsultingPrep · The Trackr — formats, timings, employer usage, negative-marking detail, tab-mechanics reports.

Candidate voice (limited; treated cautiously)

- Wall Street Oasis, The Student Room and Glassdoor threads on Schrodgers and peer firms — process timelines and difficulty impressions, quoted only via snippets where direct access was blocked.

Known gaps, stated honestly

- Aon's full technical manuals (reliability/validity coefficients, exact norm tables, precise penalty arithmetic) are not public; the flat -1 penalty is the best-supported reading.
- No Schrodgers-specific evidence of a supervised re-test was found; the re-test policy in chapter 3 is Aon's general guidance and firm-level application varies.
- The wrong-tab submission penalty is a consistent multi-vendor report, not confirmed in Aon's own documents — this guide treats it as cheap insurance either way.

Prepared for personal test preparation. Not affiliated with, or endorsed by, Aon plc or any employer named. All scoring reconstructions are best-evidence readings of a deliberately confidential system; percentile/Stanine figures quoted from vendors are directional.